

Learn Copywriting: Beginner's Guide

Lesson 3: Headline Formulas that Grab Attention

Headline Formulas that Grab Attention - Study Notes

Key Concepts

1. **Formulaic structure** – Using a repeatable pattern makes headline creation faster and more reliable.
2. **Specificity & time frames** – Adding concrete numbers, days, or results boosts credibility and curiosity.
3. **Benefit first language** – Headlines should promise a clear advantage or solution to the reader's problem.
4. **Emotional triggers** – Words like “secret,” “proven,” or “instant” tap into desire, fear, or excitement.
5. **Adaptability** – Each formula can be tweaked for different niches, media (blog, email, ad), and audience levels.

Summary

Writing headlines that stop scrolling is a skill that can be taught with a handful of proven formulas. By plugging your topic into a tested structure, you guarantee that the headline contains the three ingredients readers subconsciously look for: **specificity**, **benefit**, and **emotional pull**.

The lesson introduces five core formulas, such as “How to ___ in ___ Days,” and shows how each can be customized with numbers, power words, and audience focused language. Practicing these patterns not only speeds up the copy writing process but also improves conversion rates because the headline instantly signals relevance and value.

Important Points

- **Formula #1** – “How to ___ in ___ Days”
 - Promise a quick, measurable result.
 - Use realistic time frames (e.g., 7, 30, 90 days).
- **Formula #2** – “The ___ Secret/Trick/Method That ___”
 - Introduces intrigue (“secret”) and a payoff (“boost sales 200%”).
- **Formula #3** – “X Ways to ___ Without ___”
 - Lists (X) create scannability; “Without” removes a common objection.
- **Formula #4** – “Are You ___? Here’s What Happens Next”
 - Turns a question into a self diagnosis, then offers the next step.
- **Formula #5** – “What ___ Can Teach You About ___”
 - Leverages analogies or unexpected comparisons to spark curiosity.
- **Numbers matter** – Odd numbers (3, 5, 7) often perform better than even ones.

- **Power words** – “Instant,” “Proven,” “Free,” “Ultimate,” “Fail Proof,” etc., increase click through.
- **Audience focus** – Replace generic nouns with the reader’s identity (“Marketers,” “New Parents”).
- **Test & iterate** – Even proven formulas should be A/B tested with your specific audience.

Examples

Example 1 – Using Formula #1

Headline: “How to Double Your Email List in 14 Days”

- **How it works:**
 - **How to** !’ signals a step by step guide.
 - **Double Your Email List** !’ clear, high value benefit.
 - **in 14 Days** !’ specific, short time frame that creates urgency.

Example 2 – Using Formula #3

Headline: “7 Ways to Lose Belly Fat Without Giving Up Pizza”

- **How it works:**
 - **7 Ways** !’ list format, promises multiple tips.
 - **Lose Belly Fat** !’ primary desire of the target audience.
 - **Without Giving Up Pizza** !’ removes a perceived barrier, making the promise feel attainable.

Quick Review

1. Why do numbers (especially odd ones) improve headline performance?
2. Rewrite the headline “Boost Your Sales” using Formula #2.
3. What emotional trigger is introduced by the word “secret” in a headline?
4. How can you adapt “How to ___ in ___ Days” for a long term program?
5. List two power words you could swap into any of the five formulas to increase urgency.

Further Reading

- **Copywriting Foundations:** “The Psychology of Headlines” – deep dive into why certain words convert.
- **Data Driven Writing:** A/B testing headline variations and interpreting results.
- **Advanced Formulas:** Swipe file collections of high performing headlines across industries.
- **Audience Research:** Techniques for uncovering the specific pain points and language your target market uses.

